Pointing to ongoing military operations in FATA and terrorist violence savaging the country, one senior official in the security services asserted that Pakistan did not have the capacity to deal with Lashkar at present. He said that first al-Qaeda and the Pakistani Taliban must be eliminated. Although he admitted Lashkar shared their extremist ideology, he indicated dealing with it would have to wait because it was not an immediate threat to the state.[3] Numerous other interlocutors inside or close to the Pakistani security establishment echoed this argument for triage, and asserted that in the short-term Pakistan must avoid taking any action that would lead Lashkar as an organization to become more involved in the insurgency against the state. Members of the security services are particularly concerned about opening up a second front in Punjab province, where Lashkar is based. They believe doing so would lead the group to intensify its collaboration with other militants, including al-Qaeda and the Pakistani Taliban, to help them escalate the tempo and scale of attacks in that province. There is a strong sense, which is not entirely unfounded, that the police are illequipped to deal with the ramifications were this to occur and that the army might need to be called in. The army is not only overstretched, but its ranks also draw heavily from Punjab province and so initiating operations there could destabilize it as an institution as well as the country.

It would be naïve to suggest Pakistan should not first focus on the militants currently attacking its people. But fear of acting against Lashkar is not the only reason it is still allowed to operate. The group continues to be used as a proxy against India and elements within the army and ISI clearly wish to maintain this capability. In a moment of candor, an ISI officer asked rhetorically, ‘Who benefits if we go after the Lashkar? And who pays?’ His response: ‘India and Pakistan.’[4] Members of the Pakistani security establishment remain convinced that India poses an existential threat. Indeed, the army is overstretched partly because many of its troops are deployed to counter possible Indian aggression, making them unavailable to take on Pakistan’s own militants. The disparity between the two countries in terms of size and economic strength creates an attendant variation in their respective conventional military capacity, which may only grow with time. Developing a nuclear capability was one means of redressing this imbalance; reliance on irregular outfits like Lashkar is another. It is therefore impossible to de-link the issue of support for the